# My Journey in Networking

Networking has been one of the most transformative areas in my academic and professional growth. From learning basic computer communication concepts to configuring enterprise routers and switches, my journey in networking has shaped my career direction and strengthened my technical confidence.

In this article, I share my experience learning computer networking, configuring routers and switches and understanding network security concepts.

## Discovering Networking

My journey began with understanding how computers communicate within a network. I learned foundational concepts such as:

- IP addressing
- Subnetting
- OSI Model
- TCP/IP Model
- LANs and WANs

Understanding how data moves from one device to another gave me a new perspective on how the internet works behind the scenes.

## Learning to Configure Routers

One of the most exciting milestones was configuring Cisco routers using Cisco IOS. Working with devices like the Cisco 2900 Series Integrated Services Routers helped me understand real-world network infrastructure.

I practiced:

- Setting hostnames
- Configuring IP addresses
- Setting static routes
- Implementing dynamic routing protocols
- Securing router access with passwords and SSH

At first, the command-line interface felt intimidating, but over time, it became a powerful tool that I now enjoy using.

## Configuring Switches and VLANs

Switch configuration introduced me to:

- VLAN creation
- Trunk and access ports
- Inter-VLAN routing
- MAC address tables

This helped me understand how organizations segment networks for security and performance.

## Understanding Network Security

Networking is incomplete without security. I learned key security concepts such as:

- Securing remote access using SSH
- Disabling unused ports
- Implementing access control lists (ACLs)
- Basic firewall principles
- Identifying common network threats

Security made me realize that a network engineer is not only responsible for connectivity but also for protecting digital assets.

## Troubleshooting Skills

Through practical sessions and hands-on experience, I developed troubleshooting skills using commands such as:

- `show ip interface brief`
- `show ip route`
- `ping`
- `traceroute`

I learned that most network problems are caused by simple misconfigurations — such as incorrect IP addresses or shutdown interfaces.

## How Networking Shaped My Career Vision

My journey in networking has strengthened my interest in becoming a professional network engineer. Each configuration task, troubleshooting session, and security implementation has increased my confidence.

Networking has taught me:

- Logical thinking
- Problem-solving
- Patience
- Attention to detail

It is more than a technical field, it is a discipline that requires precision and continuous learning.

# Conclusion

My journey in networking is still ongoing. With each new concept I learn, I move closer to mastering enterprise-level network design and security implementation.

I believe networking is not just about cables and commands it is about connecting systems, people and opportunities.